PRODUCT DELIVERY

Common Pitfalls

The five mistakes new Product Owners make most often, how other mistakes group into a few categories, and a short checklist to avoid them.

Patterns that repeat

Most of the mistakes new Product Owners make are not unique to any one company or team. The same handful of patterns show up again and again, and recognising them early is often more useful than memorising any single framework.

Five common pitfalls

The most common starting point is building solutions before understanding the problem: jumping to features without validating what customers actually need, or spending too little time on research and evidence before committing to a direction. The useful corrective is to fall in love with the problem rather than the solution. Closely related is prioritising by opinion rather than value, saying yes to whoever is loudest or most senior rather than weighing customer value, business impact, effort and strategic fit against each other, usually because no clear prioritisation framework or product goal exists to settle the argument instead.

A third pattern is treating the backlog as a to-do list: filling it with every request that comes in and rarely removing anything, until it holds hundreds of low-value items kept "just in case." A healthy backlog is curated and regularly refined, not just accumulated. Fourth, and echoing From Output to Outcome, is focusing on output rather than outcome: measuring success by how many features shipped rather than asking what customer or business change was meant to happen, and how the team would know if it had. Fifth is working in isolation, writing requirements alone and handing them to developers rather than involving engineers, designers, stakeholders and customers early enough that the product benefits from their input rather than just their execution.

Other mistakes by category

Beyond these five, most other common mistakes cluster into the same handful of underlying categories. Under understanding sit things like confusing what a customer asks for with what they actually need, or skipping discovery and moving straight to delivery without checking the opportunity is worth pursuing. Under direction sits the absence of a clear product vision, which leaves a team unable to make good calls on its own. Under decision-making sit habits like changing priorities too often for a team to finish anything, or applying frameworks such as OKRs or the Kano model mechanically rather than understanding the thinking behind them. Under collaboration sit weak stakeholder communication and

treating developers as a feature factory rather than partners. And under learning sit the failure to validate assumptions before building, ignoring usage data and feedback in favour of intuition, and assuming the job ends at release rather than continuing to monitor and adapt afterward.

A short checklist

Taken together, the five original pitfalls are worth keeping as a short checklist: solve the right problem, prioritise for value, keep the backlog healthy, measure outcomes rather than output, and collaborate continuously.

Online version with links to related resources: https://resources.simsab.net/product-ownership/common-pitfalls